A SYSTEM SUFFERS DEATH BY CONTAMINATION

Four maternal deaths after caesareans at Kota hospitals shake up the Rajasthan health establishment. The needle of suspicion points to spurious drugs

pictures, as family members protested with the newborns outside the two hospitals: the New Medical College Hospital (NMCH) and JK Lone Hospital.

Each of the cases had a common pattern: crashing blood pressure, sharply reduced urine output, rapid deterioration and then outright failure of the kidneys. That triggers suspicion of the worst: contaminated medicines or even injectible ingredients, going alongside the usual curse of poor sanitation and infection control, leading to post-op sepsis. The thought has shaken up Rajasthan's medical establishment.

Takeaways

- **Five women dead, many critical after C-section in Kota**
- **Common patterns suggest contaminated medicines as cause**
- **State bans 24 drugs, devices linked to deaths, including IV fluids**



AVOIDABLE TRAGEDY Clockwise from left: Pinki, one of the victims; Congress workers protest the deaths; the infant of another victim, Arti, with a relative

Photographs by: AH ZAIDI

The first alarm came when six women who underwent caesareans within hours of each other at NMCH developed severe complications soon after surgery. The first casualty came on May 5. The others were shifted to ICUs and nephrology wards, but that didn't help. The second death came on May 7. Within the week, the toll reached four. On May 17, a pregnant woman, admitted for a small surgery, also died.

The distraught families alleged negligence and delayed treatment even into the crisis. As the images of the 'Protests With the Newborns' outside the hospitals went viral, Congress workers, too, joined in and soon the crisis had assumed the shape of a political flashpoint. The Opposition was not about to let go of the chance: Rajasthan was already at the centre of the NEET paper leak; now, health was being shown up alongside education as a sick sector.

SUSPECT DRUGS, DEVICES

The state is trying to tamp down on things with action. Besides one contract doctor's service termination, a few suspensions and notices, Rajasthan's Drug Control Department has also halted the use and distribution of 24 medicines and devices linked to the cases. The list includes IV fluids, injections, catheters, syringes and antibiotics supplied through the Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation Limited (RMSCL) as well as items purchased on the open market.

Officials have not confirmed spurious drugs, but doctors involved in the inquiry concede the clinical pattern is "highly unusual without any explanation". Only one post-mortem has been conducted so far, and that report has not been made public. ■